

INKSCAPE

Designing stock vector graphics calls for intense knowledge of Adobe Illustrator. The paid tool is a one-stop shop for all vector design needs. But we're not pirates here are we? Enter Inkscape – a free and open source tool to design professional vector graphics. This easy-to-use tool is also easier to master, learn the basics and jump into these advanced tips and tricks to make vector graphics on the go.

If you don't already have it, download it here: <https://inkscape.org/en/>

Reduce system lag while designing heavy graphics

Designing heavy, vector-based artwork demands more computation – calling more CPU cycles – that, in turn, makes your system slow. If you don't want to upgrade to better hardware, follow these three simple tricks to reduce system lag.

Your system usually starts lagging if the number of nodes on your vector graphics increases. Nodes are the points on the edges of your graphic that gives it shape. In order to reduce lag, avoid all the unnecessary nodes.

Another reason for the lag is use of filters. Filters such as “Gaussian blur” make the object heavy. To deal with it, place the object (on which the filter has been applied) on a different layer. When editing your vector, you can hide the layer to avoid it from demanding more computational resources. Zooming in close to the object also degrades your system performance, so it's recommended that you zoom out and edit your objects.

Transform selective nodes

You can give an object an entirely different identity by selectively transforming its nodes. Suppose

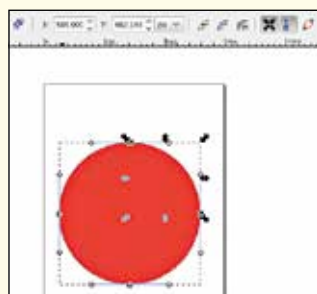


Inkscape09

Downloading like a boss10

Tips & Tricks has its own page numbers, and does not follow the rest of the magazine's page numbers. This is done to ensure that you can cut out and save T&T in a separate folder for later reference.

you have an object. First, convert it to a path and then press [F2] to edit path by nodes. Then,



The four-arrow icon on the toolbar shows the transformation handles

select two or more successive nodes and click on “Show transformation handles for selected nodes” located on the toolbar at the top. Transformation handles will then appear; you can move the handles to give any shape to the object.

Paste in place

If you perform regular copy-paste jobs on an object, Inkscape pastes it right under the mouse cursor. However, if you want to paste it in the original position, use [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [V] instead of regular [Ctrl] + [V].

Paste with style

You can also carry forward the style of one object to another without the need of tweaking its properties. Do this with the help of the “Paste Style” feature that applies the style (fill, stroke and font settings) of the first object from the clipboard to the current selection. To use the feature, hit [Shift] + [Ctrl] + [V] while pasting.

Create your own default template

If you don't want to set the page according to your standards

each time you launch Inkscape, this tip is for you. This you can do by creating a template, which is shown to you whenever you launch Inkscape. It's an easy way to quickly get to the more engaging task of designing.

To create a default template, open ‘Document Properties’ by navigating to File > Document Properties or by pressing [Shift] + [Ctrl] + [D]. Change the size of the document in the ‘Custom Size’ section as per your preferences. Next, to permanently keep these settings save this file as “default.svg” at the following path:

For Windows: C:\Users\[Username]\AppData\Roaming\inkscape\templates\

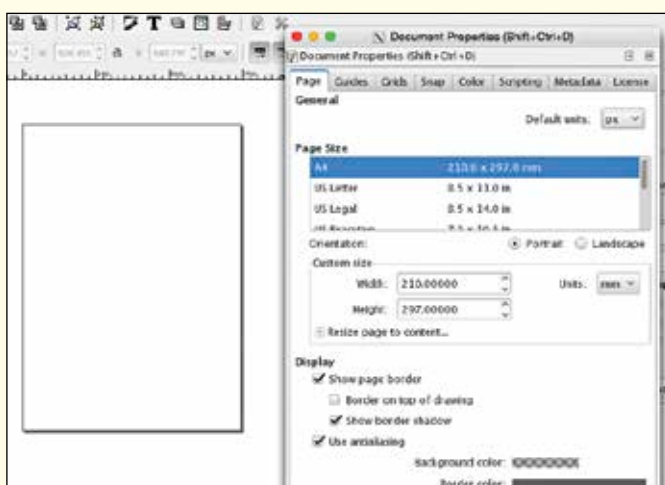
For Linux: ~/home/username/.config/inkscape/templates/

For Mac: /Applications/Inkscape.app/Contents/Resources/templates/

That's it. Every time you launch Inkscape, you'll be presented with your custom template.

Use the XML editor

Inkscape provides a built-in XML editor that displays the entire tree of the document. You can edit the document and find the corresponding changes in the XML tree. XML editor can



Change the size once and get the same dimensions every time